

CASE-03

# Two gaps. Only one is a growth problem.

Activation sits at 25% against a 40% benchmark. Organic acquisition sits at 20% against 40%. A plan to close both — and a framework for deciding whether to pay for referrals at all.

SELF-DIRECTED CASE STUDY

**Nabil Hakeem**

Growth analysis · Validation design · Prioritisation

[linkedin.com/in/nabil-hakeem-pm](https://www.linkedin.com/in/nabil-hakeem-pm)

# Three problems, and one of them is an argument.

**Activation:** a fifteen-point gap to benchmark. The likely causes are an unclear value proposition at onboarding, friction in the first point-earning journey, no immediate reward, and no guidance on where points can even be earned.

**Acquisition:** organic is half the industry benchmark. Word of mouth is unused, physical touchpoints carry almost no visibility, and search presence is thin.

**The merchant list:** heavy drop-off, and a team split three ways on whether it's normal behaviour, a broken screen, or a screen that shouldn't exist.

The gaps

SIGNUP → ACTIVATION

**25% vs 40%**

ORGANIC ACQUISITION

**20% vs 40%**

MERCHANT LIST

**Disputed**

# How do you settle a disagreement about a screen?

Three colleagues have three explanations for the same drop-off, and all three are plausible.

## REDESIGN IT NOW

Pick the most senior person's theory, rebuild the screen, and find out in six weeks whether it was the right theory.

## VALIDATE IN THREE PHASES

Funnel analytics and heatmaps, then micro-surveys and usability tests, then hypothesis testing. Fix what the data names.

The validation phase costs a fraction of the redesign and it forecloses the argument. **Only then** does the fix branch — technical if it's performance, layout if it's usability, removal if the screen genuinely earns nothing.

# What I proposed, and why.

## 1 • Front-load the very first reward

Points on verification, more on the first transaction, double on the first three.  
The fastest initiative to ship and the largest single expected lift in activation.

## 2 • Buy visibility where intent already exists

QR at the pump, point-of-sale prompts, receipt codes — reaching the customer  
at the moment they're already engaged with the brand, not scrolling elsewhere.

## 3 • Pilot the referral programme to 20% of the base

Dual-sided incentives, A/B tested structures, fraud controls, and a ninety-day  
evaluation window before anything scales.

## 4 • Judge referrals on LTV:CAC, not on referral count

Referral volume is a vanity number — a programme can grow enrolment and  
lose money on every signup. Below 3:1 it doesn't scale, however good the chart  
looks.

# I refused to redesign the merchant list before instrumenting it.

It was the most visible problem and the one everybody had an opinion about, which made it the most tempting thing to start building. Three competing theories and no data is not a design brief.

## Six-month targets

Activation 25% → 40%

Organic 20% → 40%

Drop-off -50%

LTV:CAC > 3:1

## What I took from it

A team disagreeing about why users leave a screen doesn't have a design problem — it has a measurement gap. The cheapest thing you can build is the instrumentation that ends the argument.

Happy to talk through the thinking —  
[linkedin.com/in/nabil-hakeem-pm](https://www.linkedin.com/in/nabil-hakeem-pm)